

24 Days of Play

Winter Countdown

One easy play a day for 24 winter days, made from things you already have. Start any day you like.



24

PLAYS, ONE A DAY

22

NEED NOTHING TO BUY

0-5

MINUTES TO SET UP
MOST DAYS

2+

YEARS, WITH A
GROWN-UP

Prep: about 15 minutes to print and cut the 12 card pages, once. No time to cut? Use the countdown board and the list page.

- ✓ 24 play cards with a talk line and safety line
- ✓ Easier, harder and 2-minute versions
- ✓ A countdown board, plus a blank one
- ✓ 24 number tags and a fridge certificate



Paper Snowball
Toss



Bear Cave



Ice Rescue



Penguin Waddle



Night Sky
Window



Flashlight
Shadow Show



Mitten Friend
Says Hello



Cozy Book Nest

How the countdown works

Winter days can be long and dark. This countdown gives each one a small, warm play to look forward to. It takes about two minutes to start, and there is no wrong way to do it.

1 Print

Print pages 6–23 (or the whole file). Card stock is nice but plain paper works.

2 Pick a way

Cut the 12 card pages in half and tuck each card in an envelope, bag or jar with its number tag. Or skip the cutting and use the board.

3 Pick a start day

Any day works. Many families start on the first of the month; others start the first snowy week or the first day of a break.

Three ways to use it

Card a day

Open one numbered card each morning. Play it when it suits your day, even at bedtime.

Board only

Hang the countdown board. Read the day's play from the list page. Your child marks the square after you play.

Pick and choose

Skip a day, swap two days, play a favorite twice. The numbers are there to help, not to boss you around.



Most children love 2–3 of these and want them again and again. That's the countdown working. Play the favorites as often as you like, and let the rest wait for another winter.

Why a play a day?

Young children learn words and ideas in back-and-forth moments with the people who love them: a look, a laugh, a turn, a word. A short play each day adds more of those moments to ordinary winter days. The screens in your home keep their usual spot; this is simply something warm to add.

A peek at the first week

Day 1



Paper Snowball Toss
No prep

Day 2



Mitten Match
Prep 2 min

Day 3



Foggy Window Drawing
No prep

Day 4



Bear Cave
Prep 2 min

Day 5



Ice Rescue
Prep 2 min

Day 6



Penguin Waddle
No prep

Day 7



Dress Teddy for Snow
No prep

Talk while you play

Every card has one talk line. You don't need to say it word for word. These three moves do most of the work:

Pause and wait

Say a little, then stop and count to five in your head. A look, a sound or a wiggle is an answer.

"Ready, set... (wait)"

Say what you see

Put words to what your child is doing, right as it happens. No quiz questions needed.

"Drip, drip. It's melting!"

Offer a choice

Hold up two things and wait. Pointing and reaching count as answers.

"Big cup or little cup?"

 **Talk, sing and read in the language you know best.** Every talk line works in any language. A sign, a point or a tap on a talking device counts as communicating, just like a word.

How to read a play card

DAY
3

Foggy Window Drawing



★ from 30 mo
With a grown-up

From 30 mo
No prep
No mess
About 5 min
Nothing to buy

You need: A cold window

- Breathe on a cold window to make a foggy patch.
- Draw a dot, a line or a smile with one finger.
- Watch it fade, then make another.

Make it easier: You make the fog; your child pokes a dot in it.

Make it harder: Draw a snowflake, a sun or the first letter of a name.

Tired? 2-minute version: Two foggy patches, two smiley faces, done.

Safety: Use a closed window your child can reach from the floor. No climbing on sills or furniture.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY • SAY WHAT YOU SEE

"Huff! It's foggy... now it's gone!"

- Day number and name.** Use them in order or not.
- Age label.** Color, shape and words, from the play's own starting age: ★ **from 2 yrs**, ★ **from 30 mo** or ● **from 3 yrs**.
- Prep, mess and time.** Play times are rough; stop whenever your child is done.
- Nothing to buy.** 22 of the 24 plays use only things most homes have.
- Easier, harder and 2-minute versions.** Tired? The 2-minute version still counts.
- Safety line.** Read it before you start. A grown-up is always there.

If today isn't the day

Not interested?

Try the 2-minute version, or let your child pick a different day. Watching you play counts too.

Busy week?

Play two short days at the weekend. There's no streak to keep and nothing to make up.

Two children?

Give each a job: one holds, one pours; one hides, one seeks. Take turns being the leader.

Our safety rules

Every play in this countdown follows these rules, and each card has its own safety line. You know your child best: skip or change anything that doesn't suit them.



A grown-up plays too

Every play is for a child and a grown-up together. Stay close and watch.



The toilet-paper tube test

For children under 3, anything that fits through a toilet-paper tube (about 1.25 in or 3.2 cm across) stays out of reach. When in doubt, leave it out.



Water and ice

Stay within arm's reach during any water play, even a tray of melting ice. Warm water only: test it on your wrist.



No cords, no balloons

No cords, strings, scarves or ties long enough to go around a neck. No balloons for children under 8.



Food and allergies

Soft food cut small and thin, eaten sitting down. No whole grapes, nuts, popcorn, marshmallows or hard candy for little ones. Check allergies first.



Lights, batteries and heat

Use a flashlight with a screwed-shut battery door and keep button batteries away from children. Keep hot drinks and the stove out of every play.



Windows and climbing

Look through closed windows from the floor. A grown-up lifts; nobody stands on sills or furniture.



Cold days outside

Dress for the weather and come in when little hands and noses feel cold. Hold hands near roads.

These are everyday play ideas for families, not medical or developmental advice. Questions about your child's growth or health? Your child's doctor is a good place to start.

What you'll need

22 of the 24 plays need nothing to buy. Gather a few of these as you go; there is no need to set everything up at once.

Paper and crayons

Day 1, 10, 11, 21, 24

A laundry basket

Day 1

Mittens, gloves, socks

Day 2, 6, 7, 18, 22

A blanket and pillows

Day 4, 20

A table

Day 4

A plastic tub, a baking tray, spoons

Day 5

Big bath toys

Day 5

A teddy or doll, a hat, a small towel

Day 7

Cups, a pot, spoons

Day 8, 19

Warm clothes

Day 9, 22

Tape

Day 11, 21

Music, or your singing

Day 12

A window

Day 3, 13, 16

A flashlight and 2–3 toys

Day 14

Toast, a soft spread, a banana

Day 15

Sofa cushions

Day 17

One toy to hide

Day 23

This countdown

Day 24

One play needs a head start

Day 5, Ice Rescue: freeze the toys in a tub of water the night before (about 2 minutes). Put a reminder on Day 4.

Two plays may need something

Day 11, Paper Snowflakes: child-safe scissors.
Day 15, Snowy Toast: toast, a soft spread and a banana. Swap in any other day if you don't have them.

Prep plan

Once, about 15 minutes: print, cut the card pages in half along the dashed line, cut out the number tags and hang the board.

Each day, 0–5 minutes: read the card, gather what it needs, play.

No time to cut? Hang the board and read each day's play from the list on page 8.

Our winter countdown



After each day's play, your child colors the circle or adds a sticker. Play the days in any order.

1 Paper Snowball Toss	2 Mitten Match	3 Foggy Window Drawing	4 Bear Cave
5 Ice Rescue	6 Penguin Waddle	7 Dress Teddy for Snow	8 Pretend Cocoa Café
9 Winter Walk Hunt	10 Draw a Snow Friend	11 Paper Snowflakes	12 Freeze Like an Icicle
13 Night Sky Window	14 Flashlight Shadow Show	15 Snowy Toast	16 Bird Watch
17 Cushion Snow Friend	18 Mitten Friend Says Hello	19 Winter Storm Band	20 Cozy Book Nest
21 Animal Tracks Trail	22 Warm or Cold? Clothes Sort	23 Warmer, Colder	24 Our Favorite Day

Our winter countdown



Write or draw your own plays in the squares, or type them in before you print. Mark the circle after each day.

1	2	3	4
5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12
13	14	15	16
17	18	19	20
21	22	23	24

All 24 plays at a glance

Read the day's play here if you're using the board only. The full card, with its talk line and safety line, is on the page shown.

DAY	PLAY	YOU NEED	AGE	CARD
1	 Paper Snowball Toss	Scrap paper, a laundry basket	24 mo+	p. 9
2	 Mitten Match	Everyone's mittens, gloves and socks	24 mo+	p. 9
3	 Foggy Window Drawing	A cold window	30 mo+	p. 10
4	 Bear Cave	A blanket, a table	24 mo+	p. 10
5	 Ice Rescue	A plastic tub, water, 3 big bath toys, a baking tray, spoons	30 mo+	p. 11
6	 Penguin Waddle	Two socks rolled into a ball	24 mo+	p. 11
7	 Dress Teddy for Snow	A teddy or doll, a hat, socks, a small towel	24 mo+	p. 12
8	 Pretend Cocoa Café	Cups, a pot, a spoon	24 mo+	p. 12
9	 Winter Walk Hunt	Warm clothes	24 mo+	p. 13
10	 Draw a Snow Friend	Paper, crayons	24 mo+	p. 13
11	 Paper Snowflakes	Paper, child-safe scissors, tape	42 mo+	p. 14
12	 Freeze Like an Icicle	Any music, or your singing	24 mo+	p. 14
13	 Night Sky Window	A window after dark	24 mo+	p. 15
14	 Flashlight Shadow Show	A flashlight, a blank wall, 2–3 toys	30 mo+	p. 15
15	 Snowy Toast	Toast, a soft spread, a banana, a spoon	24 mo+	p. 16
16	 Bird Watch	A window	24 mo+	p. 16
17	 Cushion Snow Friend	3 sofa cushions or pillows	24 mo+	p. 17
18	 Mitten Friend Says Hello	A mitten or a clean sock	24 mo+	p. 17
19	 Winter Storm Band	Pots, pans, wooden spoons	24 mo+	p. 18
20	 Cozy Book Nest	Pillows, a blanket, any book	24 mo+	p. 18
21	 Animal Tracks Trail	Paper, a crayon, tape	30 mo+	p. 19
22	 Warm or Cold? Clothes Sort	A few winter and summer clothes	30 mo+	p. 19
23	 Warmer, Colder	One toy, bigger than your hand	36 mo+	p. 20
24	 Our Favorite Day	This countdown, crayons	24 mo+	p. 20

DAY
1

Paper Snowball Toss

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo 🕒 No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ About 10 min 📦 Nothing to buy

You need: Scrap paper, a laundry basket

- 1 Crumple sheets of paper into big snowballs.
- 2 Take turns tossing them into the basket.
- 3 After each round, everyone takes one giant step back.

✓ **Make it easier:** Stand right by the basket and drop them in.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Count the snowballs that land in. Try the other hand.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Three snowballs each, one throw each, then tidy up together.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT
“Ready, set... (wait) throw!”

✓ **Safety:** Crumple whole sheets into big balls. Pick up small torn bits so they stay out of mouths.

✂️ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
2

Mitten Match

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo 🕒 Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ About 5 min 📦 Nothing to buy

You need: Everyone's mittens, gloves and socks

- 1 Tip everyone's mittens, gloves and socks into one pile.
- 2 Find the pairs together.
- 3 Hold one up and ask, “Where's its friend?”

✓ **Make it easier:** Start with 3 pairs in very different colors.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Sort by owner too: “Whose mittens are these?”

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Match two pairs, then wave hello with mitten hands.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE
“Same! ... Not the same.”

✓ **Safety:** Take off any cords or clips that join mittens before you play.

DAY
3

Foggy Window Drawing

★ from 30 mo

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 30 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 5 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: A cold window

- 1 Breathe on a cold window to make a foggy patch.
- 2 Draw a dot, a line or a smile with one finger.
- 3 Watch it fade, then make another.

✓ **Make it easier:** You make the fog; your child pokes a dot in it.

⬆ **Make it harder:** Draw a snowflake, a sun or the first letter of a name.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Two foggy patches, two smiley faces, done.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE
“Huff! It’s foggy... now it’s gone!”

✓ **Safety:** Use a closed window your child can reach from the floor. No climbing on sills or furniture.

✂ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
4

Bear Cave

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ About 15 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: A blanket, a table

- 1 Drape a blanket over a table to make a bear cave.
- 2 Your child crawls in to sleep for the winter.
- 3 When you call “Spring!”, the bear wakes with a big stretch and a roar.

✓ **Make it easier:** Lay the blanket over your knees for a mini cave.

⬆ **Make it harder:** Take turns being the bear and the one who calls “Spring!”

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Blanket over your knees, one sleepy bear, one “Spring!”

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT
“Shh... the bear is sleeping. (wait) Wake up, bear!”

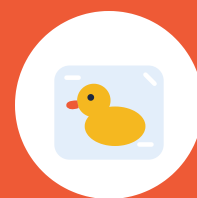
✓ **Safety:** Keep one side of the cave open. Nothing heavy, no cords or clips holding the blanket.

DAY
5

Ice Rescue

★ from 30 mo

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 30 mo ⌚ Prep 2 min (the night before) 💧 Messy ⌚ About 15 min 💰 Nothing to buy

You need: A plastic tub, water, 3 big bath toys, a baking tray, spoons

✅ **Make it easier:** Freeze a thin layer so the toys pop out fast.

- 1 The night before, freeze big bath toys in a tub of water.
- 2 Tip the ice block onto a baking tray.
- 3 Pour warm water and scrape with spoons until every toy is free.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Guess which toy will come out first. Were you right?

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Touch the ice block, then a warm cup: “Cold! Warm!”

💬 **TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**
“Drip, drip... it’s melting! Who’s coming out?”

✅ **Safety:** Toys too big to fit through a toilet-paper tube. Test warm water on your wrist. Stay within arm’s reach.

✂️ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
6

Penguin Waddle

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 5 min 💰 Nothing to buy

You need: Two socks rolled into a ball

✅ **Make it easier:** Just waddle and flap together.

- 1 Tuck your arms in, point your feet out and waddle like penguins.
- 2 Carry a rolled-up sock “egg” on your feet.
- 3 Slide on your tummies into the “sea” on the rug.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Pass the sock egg from your feet to theirs, no hands.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Waddle to the kitchen and back.

💬 **TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT**
“Waddle, waddle... stop! (wait) Waddle, waddle... go!”

✅ **Safety:** Clear a path on a rug or carpet. Roll two socks together so the egg is big.

DAY
7

Dress Teddy for Snow

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 10 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: A teddy or doll, a hat, socks, a small towel

- 1 It's snowing on Teddy's walk!
- 2 Your child picks a hat and puts it on Teddy.
- 3 Add socks for mittens and a small towel for a coat.

✅ **Make it easier:** You hold Teddy; your child pops the hat on.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Your child tells you what goes on first, next and last.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** One hat on Teddy, one hat on you. Brrr!

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · OFFER A CHOICE

"What does Teddy need? (wait) A hat or socks?"

✅ **Safety:** No scarves, ties, belts or cords. Under-3s: everything too big for a toilet-paper tube.

✂️ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
8

Pretend Cocoa Café

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ About 10 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: Cups, a pot, a spoon

- 1 Set up a pretend winter café.
- 2 Your child is the cook.
- 3 Order a warm drink, then your child stirs the pot and pours it into your cup.
- 4 Blow on it and say "Mmm!"

✅ **Make it easier:** You cook; your child stirs and hands you the cup.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Swap: you order, your child takes the order and repeats it back.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** One pretend cup each and a big "Cheers!"

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · OFFER A CHOICE

"Big cup or little cup? (wait) Sprinkles or no sprinkles?"

✅ **Safety:** Pretend drinks only. Keep real hot drinks well out of reach during play.

DAY
9

Winter Walk Hunt

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ Prep 2 min 💧 A little mess ⌚ About 15 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: Warm clothes

- 1 Bundle up and look for five winter things: a bare tree, a bird, a puddle or ice, your foggy breath and something white.
- 2 Tick each one on this card.

☐ 🌳 A bare tree ☐ 🐦 A bird ☐ 💧 A puddle or ice

☐ 🌫️ Foggy breath ☐ ❄️ Something white

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE
“I see a bird! (wait) What do you see?”

✓ **Make it easier:** Find two things from the doorstep or a window.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Find all five, then add one of your own.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Look out the window and name three winter things.

✓ **Safety:** Hold hands near roads. Look, don't taste: berries, nuts and leaves stay out of mouths.

✂️ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
10

Draw a Snow Friend

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 A little mess ⌚ About 10 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: Paper, crayons

- 1 Draw three big circles, one on top of the other.
- 2 Your child adds eyes, a smile, buttons and a hat.
- 3 Give your snow friend a name.

✓ **Make it easier:** You draw; your child dots on the buttons.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Your child draws the circles. Count the buttons together.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Draw one round face. Your child adds the eyes.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · REPEAT AND ADD ONE
“Eyes!” ... “Two big eyes!”

✓ **Safety:** Under-3s use big, palm-size crayons with a grown-up sitting alongside.

DAY
11

Paper Snowflakes

from 42 mo

With a grown-up



From 42 mo No prep A little mess About 10 min

You need: Paper, child-safe scissors, tape

- 1 Fold a square of paper in half, in half again, then into a triangle.
- 2 Snip little shapes off the edges.
- 3 Open it slowly: a snowflake!
- 4 Tape it to a window.

✓ **Make it easier:** You snip; your child opens it and finds the holes.

^ **Make it harder:** Your child snips the corners. Make one for every window.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Fold and snip one snowflake together.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE
“Snip, snip... open it... wow! What shapes can you see?”

✓ **Safety:** Child-safe scissors with a grown-up beside them. Sweep up paper bits before little ones find them.

✂ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
12

Freeze Like an Icicle

from 2 yrs

With a grown-up



From 24 mo No prep No mess About 5 min Nothing to buy

You need: Any music, or your singing

- 1 Dance to the music.
- 2 When it stops, freeze like an icicle.
- 3 Wiggle again when it starts.

✓ **Make it easier:** Give a big arm signal for “freeze” so it’s easy to see.

^ **Make it harder:** Freeze in a shape: a tall icicle, a round snowball, a flat snowflake.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** One song, three freezes.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT
“Dance, dance... (wait) FREEZE!”

✓ **Safety:** Clear a space. Bare feet or grippy socks on smooth floors.

DAY
13

Night Sky Window

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 5 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: A window after dark

- 1 Winter nights come early.
- 2 Turn off the lights and look out the window together.
- 3 Find the moon, a star and a light far away.

✓ **Make it easier:** Hold your child up to look and say what you see.

⬆ **Make it harder:** Draw what you saw before bed: the moon, stars, lights.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Lights off, one look, "Night-night, sky!"

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · OFFER A CHOICE

"I see the moon! (wait) Is it round or thin?"

✓ **Safety:** Keep windows closed and locked. A grown-up lifts; no standing on sills or furniture.

✂ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
14

Flashlight Shadow Show

★ from 30 mo

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 30 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 10 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: A flashlight, a blank wall, 2–3 toys

- 1 Dim the lights and shine the flashlight at a wall.
- 2 Hold a toy in the beam to make a big shadow.
- 3 Make it walk, jump and wave.

✓ **Make it easier:** You hold the light; your child holds the toy.

⬆ **Make it harder:** Your child holds the light and you guess the shadow.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** One toy, one shadow, one wave goodbye.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

"Big shadow... little shadow! Where did it go?"

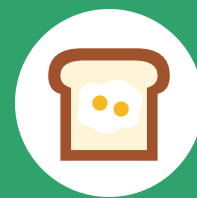
✓ **Safety:** Use a flashlight with a screwed-shut battery door. Keep button batteries away from children.

DAY
15

Snowy Toast

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ Prep 2 min 💧 A little mess ⌚ About 10 min

You need: Toast, a soft spread, a banana, a spoon

- 1 Make toast and let it cool.
- 2 Your child spreads the “snow” with the back of a spoon.
- 3 Add thin banana “footprints”, then share your snowy toast.

✓ **Make it easier:** Your child pats the spread on with the spoon.

⬆ **Make it harder:** Make a face or a snow friend out of banana slices.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** One slice of toast, one spoon of snow, shared.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT

“Spread, spread... more snow? (wait) More snow!”

✓ **Safety:** Under-3s: thin toast strips and thin half-slices of banana. Your child sits to eat. Check allergies first.

✂ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
16

Bird Watch

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 10 min ✓ **Nothing to buy**

You need: A window

- 1 Sit by a window where birds visit.
- 2 Watch together.
- 3 When a bird lands, whisper about it and copy its hops.

✓ **Make it easier:** Point and say “bird” each time one comes.

⬆ **Make it harder:** Count the birds. Can you spot two that look different?

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Look out the window for one bird. Wave to it.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT

“Tweet, tweet! (wait) Where did it go?”

✓ **Safety:** Watch through a closed window. No climbing to see.

DAY
17

Cushion Snow Friend

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 5 min 💰 Nothing to buy

You need: 3 sofa cushions or pillows

- 1 Stack three cushions into a snow friend: big, middle, small.
- 2 Give it a hat.
- 3 Then knock it over and build it again.

✅ **Make it easier:** Stack two and knock them down.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Put the cushions in order from biggest to smallest by yourself.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Stack, crash, stack again.

💬 **TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**
“Big, bigger... CRASH!”

🛡️ **Safety:** Soft cushions only, no higher than your child's chest. Nobody climbs the stack.

✂️ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
18

Mitten Friend Says Hello

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 5 min 💰 Nothing to buy

You need: A mitten or a clean sock

- 1 Put a mitten on your hand.
- 2 It becomes a chatty friend who is very cold.
- 3 It shivers, sneezes and asks your child for help getting warm.

✅ **Make it easier:** The mitten friend just waves and tickles.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Your child wears the mitten and talks to you.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Mitten on, one “Brrr!”, one hug.

💬 **TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT**
“Brrr! I’m so cold! (wait) Can you warm me up?”

🛡️ **Safety:** Use a clean mitten or sock with nothing sewn on: no buttons, beads or pom-poms.

DAY
19

Winter Storm Band

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ No prep 💧 No mess ⌚ About 10 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: Pots, pans, wooden spoons

- 1 Make a winter storm.
- 2 Bang the pots loud like thunder, tap softly like falling snow and swish like wind.
- 3 Take turns being the leader.

✅ **Make it easier:** One pot, one spoon: loud, then quiet.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Copy my pattern: tap, tap, BANG.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Three loud bangs, three quiet taps. The end!

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SING AND GESTURE

“Loud like thunder! ... Now quiet, quiet, like snow.”

✅ **Safety:** Wooden or plastic spoons. Cool, empty pots only, away from the stove.

✂️ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
20

Cozy Book Nest

★ from 2 yrs

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 24 mo ⌚ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ About 15 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: Pillows, a blanket, any book

- 1 Build a nest of pillows and a blanket on the floor.
- 2 Snuggle in with a book.
- 3 Talk about the pictures more than the words.

✅ **Make it easier:** One book, one pillow, your lap.

⬆️ **Make it harder:** Your child “reads” the book to you from the pictures.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Snuggle in and look at one page together.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

“What’s happening here? (wait)”

✅ **Safety:** The nest is for awake reading. Keep pillows and blankets out of any baby’s sleep space.

DAY
21

Animal Tracks Trail

★ from 30 mo

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 30 mo ⌚ Prep 5 min 💧 No mess ⌚ About 10 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: Paper, a crayon, tape

- 1 Trace around your child's feet on paper, six times.
- 2 Tape the footprints on the floor to make a winter trail.
- 3 Hop, tiptoe and stomp along it.

✅ **Make it easier:** Three footprints in a straight line.

🔼 **Make it harder:** Add handprints and make the trail go under the table.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Put down two footprints and jump from one to the other.

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT
"Hop, hop, hop... (wait) STOMP!"

🛡️ **Safety:** Tape each footprint flat so no one slips. Keep the trail away from stairs.

✂️ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
22

Warm or Cold? Clothes Sort

★ from 30 mo

👤 With a grown-up



👤 From 30 mo ⌚ Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ About 10 min 💚 Nothing to buy

You need: A few winter and summer clothes

- 1 Make two piles: things for a snowy day and things for a sunny day.
- 2 Hold up a hat, a sandal, a mitten or a sun hat.
- 3 Your child shows which pile it goes in.

✅ **Make it easier:** Just two things: a mitten and a sandal.

🔼 **Make it harder:** Dress up for snow, then for sun, and back again.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Hold up one mitten and one sandal: which one is for snow?

💬 TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · PAUSE AND WAIT
"Mittens: cold day! (wait) Sandals...?"

🛡️ **Safety:** No scarves, belts or cords in the pile.

DAY
23

Warmer, Colder

from 3 yrs

With a grown-up



From 36 mo No prep No mess About 10 min Nothing to buy

You need: One toy, bigger than your hand

- 1 Hide a toy while your child covers their eyes.
- 2 As they search, say “warmer” when they get close and “colder” when they move away.

✓ **Make it easier:** Hide it in plain sight, half showing.

⬆ **Make it harder:** Your child hides it and says “warmer” and “colder” to you.

2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Hide it under a cushion right beside you.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · SAY WHAT YOU SEE
“Warmer... warmer... HOT! You found it!”

✓ **Safety:** Hide only in safe, easy spots: never high up, near stairs or in cupboards with cleaners.

✂ CUT ON THE DASHED LINE · GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES

DAY
24

Our Favorite Day

from 2 yrs

With a grown-up



From 24 mo No prep A little mess About 15 min Nothing to buy

You need: This countdown, crayons

- 1 You made it to Day 24!
- 2 Look back at the board together.
- 3 Each of you picks a favorite day and plays it again.
- 4 Then color your certificate.

✓ **Make it easier:** Point to the pictures on the board and choose one.

⬆ **Make it harder:** Your child tells the story of their favorite day, start to end.

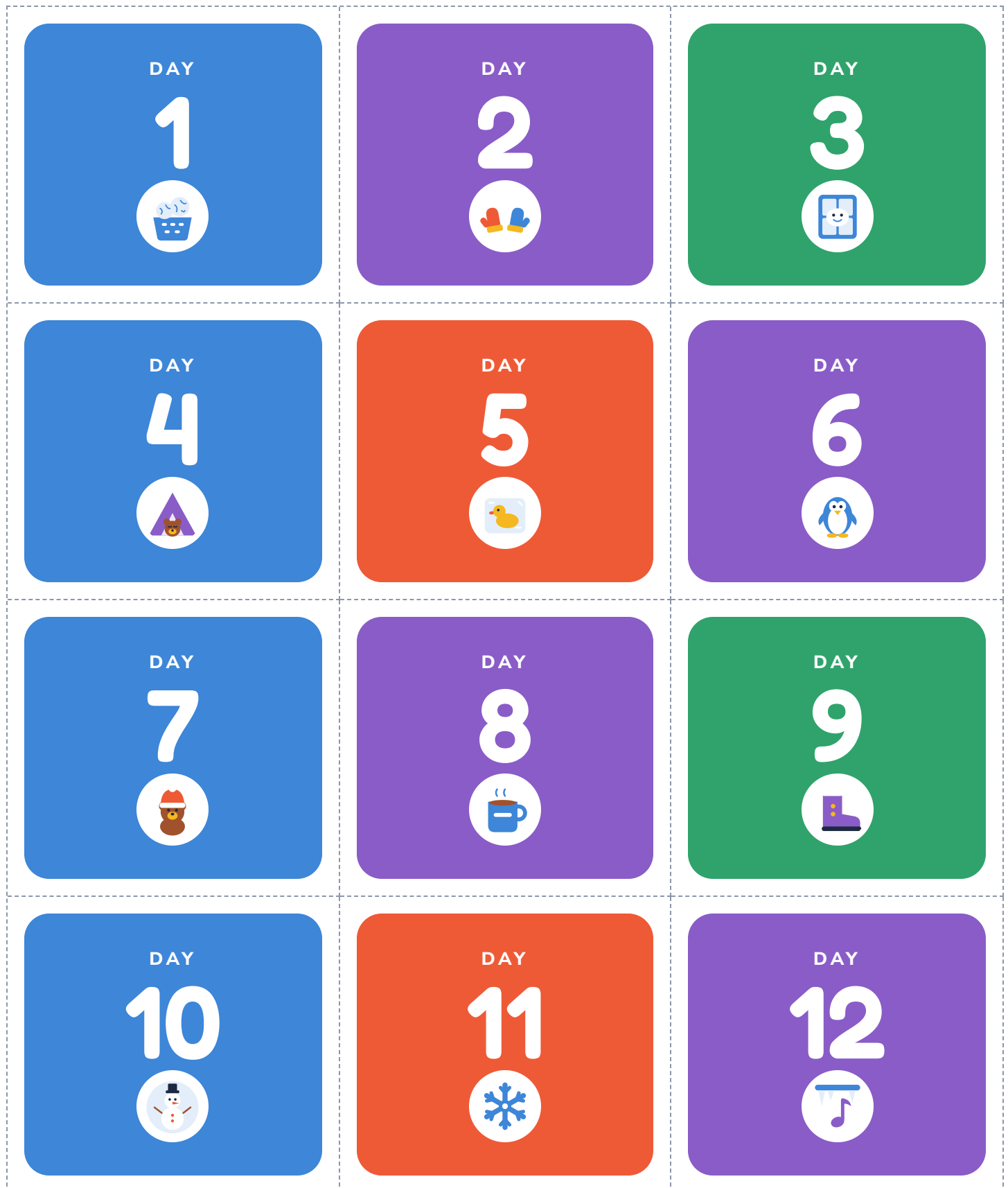
2 **Tired? 2-minute version:** Name your favorite day at bedtime.

TALK WHILE YOU PLAY · OFFER A CHOICE
“Which day was your favorite? (wait)
Mine was...”

✓ **Safety:** Follow the safety line on the day you play again.

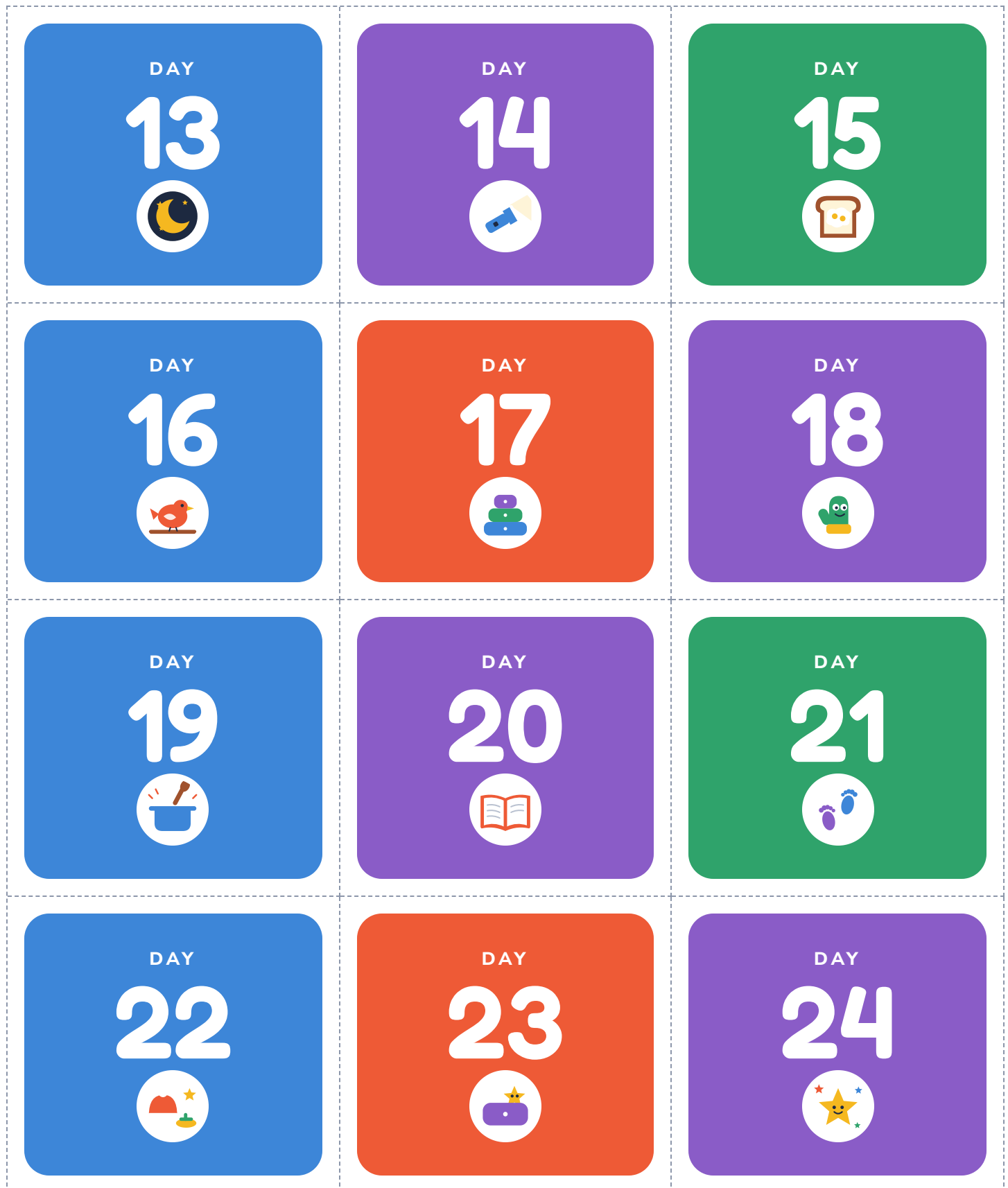
Tape a tag on each envelope, bag or jar

✂ CUT ON THE DASHED LINES • GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES



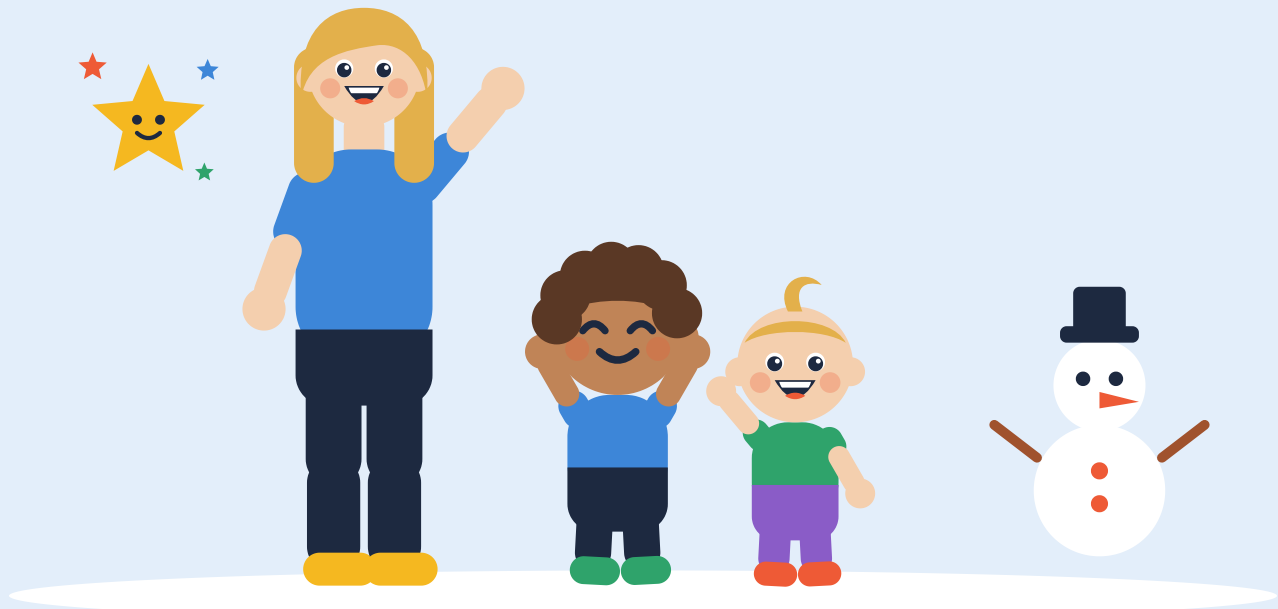
Tape a tag on each envelope, bag or jar

✂ CUT ON THE DASHED LINES • GROWN-UP KEEPS THE PIECES



We played our way through winter!

Our family



Color a snowflake for every day you played.

Our favorite day was

Date

Posting a photo? Leave out names and faces.

Good to know

Which file do I print?

Pick one: US Letter or A4, color or low-ink. Every file has the same 25 pages. Print at “Actual size” or 100%, not “Fit”.

Which pages?

Pages 6–8 (boards and list), 9–20 (play cards), 21–22 (number tags) and 23 (certificate). The guide pages are for you to read on screen.

What paper?

Plain paper is fine. Card stock makes cards and tags last longer. Laminating is optional.

We started late. Is that okay?

Yes. The plays aren't tied to dates. Start on any day and play as many days as you like.

Is this tied to a holiday?

No. It's a winter countdown for any family: snow, cold, cozy days and long nights. Use it to count down to a holiday, a break, a birthday or nothing at all.

We have a baby and a preschooler.

Every card says its starting age. Let the baby watch from a lap and keep small things out of reach. Many plays have an easier version for younger children.

Can I type in it?

Yes, in the color and low-ink files, with a free PDF reader: the blank board squares, the Winter Walk Hunt tick boxes and the certificate lines. Pictures and colors can't be changed.

Can we use it again next winter?

Yes. Print a fresh copy each year; your license doesn't expire. Children often ask for their favorite days again.

A page won't print right?

Open it in a different free PDF reader and print at 100%. Still stuck? Answers are at playbeforepixels.com/help.

Can I share it?

Your license covers one household, including grandparents and sitters who care for your child. Please don't share the files. A gift passes the license to the family who receives it.

Page map

1 cover · 2–3 grown-up guide · 4 safety rules · 5 what you need · 6 countdown board · 7 blank board · 8 all 24 plays · 9–20 play cards (Days 1–24) · 21–22 number tags · 23 certificate · 24 good to know · 25 more from Play Before Pixels

More from Play Before Pixels

Next for ages 2–5. Find them all at playbeforepixels.com.



Toddler Busy Book

74 activities for ages 1–5: matching, colors, shapes, pretend play and mazes.



"I'm Bored" Play Cards

Play cards sorted by age and energy, for the long days after the countdown ends.



52 Play & Talk Cards

One play and one talk tip on every card, for ages 0–5. A card a week for a year.



Ages 1–5 Instant Gift Bundle

The busy book, the family kit pages and two card sets in one download.



FOR GROWN-UPS Free winter bonus page

Scan for a free printable and the monthly “3 plays for your child’s age” email. We ask only for your email and, if you like, your child’s birth month and year. Never names.

playbeforepixels.com/bonus/winter-countdown · Lost your files?

playbeforepixels.com/help

24 Days of Play: Winter Countdown, ages 2–5 edition. Version 1.0 · September 2026. Everyday play ideas for families, not medical or developmental advice. Every play follows our published safety rules; a grown-up is always there.

Personal license: one household, including grandparents and sitters who care for your child. Please don't resell or share the files.

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